

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN GUINEA-BISSAU

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Guinea-Bissau is a small West African republic of mangrove estuaries, tidal flats, low-lying coast, and the offshore **Bijagós Archipelago** — a UNESCO Biosphere Reserve of some eighty-eight islands where saltwater hippos wade the tidal channels at dusk, where more green turtles nest than almost anywhere else in Africa, and where West African manatees, Atlantic humpback dolphins, and vast flocks of migratory shorebirds gather. And, distinctively, the indigenous **Bijagó people** have, through their sacred forests, their customary law, and their taboos, conserved this treasure for generations — a proven, living community stewardship of a kind found almost nowhere else in this series. Yet the archipelago is pressed hard by foreign fishing, the cashew economy, and the deep poverty of a nation whose economy leans almost entirely on the cashew harvest and the sale of its offshore fishing access, and whose politics have seen more coups than almost any nation since independence. There is no landmark community victory to point to. But a proven custodianship and genuine conservation partnerships give real ground.

Those who would defend Guinea-Bissau's archipelago work with real tools, resting on that proven custodianship. The distinctive lever is the **Bijagós Biosphere Reserve and the Bijagó custodianship** — the sacred forests, customary law, and community stewardship that have conserved the islands for generations, backed by the international conservation designation. The **offshore fishing that depletes the waters** can be pressed through the reform and transparency of the fishing-access agreements and the anti-illegal-fishing frameworks. The **logging** can be addressed through forest governance and law. The **mangroves and the coast** can be defended through conservation and the traditional rice-farming system that sustains them. Major projects must reckon with **environmental assessment**. And the **conservation, community, and international partners and frameworks** offer real channels a fragile state affords. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The pressures — the overfishing, the cashew monoculture, the logging — are driven by deep poverty and a fragile economy, so they cannot be met by enforcement alone, and the poor who fish and farm to survive must never be punished. The state itself sells the fishing access that depletes the waters. The governance is chronically unstable and strained by drug-trafficking, which must be kept clear of absolutely and handled with strict neutrality and care. And there is no landmark victory to point to. So the work must be careful, custodianship- and conservation-channelled, keeping clear of the trafficking and the political turmoil, protecting everyone involved — and the honest prize is the archipelago defended, the fishing pressed toward reform, the forests and mangroves protected, resting on the proven Bijagó stewardship, not a single triumphant stop.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You defend Guinea-Bissau's treasure not against a single enemy but by building on what already works: the proven Bijagó custodianship and the Biosphere Reserve. Strengthen the traditional stewardship and the conservation designation; press the offshore fishing toward reform and against illegal fishing; address the logging through forest governance; defend the mangroves and the traditional rice system; use the conservation, community, and international partners — all carefully, keeping clear of the trafficking and the politics, and never punishing the poor who fish and farm to survive.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Guinea-Bissau is a fragile, unstable setting, and honesty about that is the first discipline. The pressures are driven by deep poverty, so they cannot be met by enforcement alone; the state itself sells the fishing access that depletes the waters; the governance is chronically unstable and strained by drug-trafficking that must be kept clear of; and there is no landmark victory. But it also holds a genuine strength found almost nowhere else: a proven, living community custodianship. So aim at the winnable and the proven — the archipelago defended, the fishing reformed, the forests and mangroves protected — building on the Bijagó stewardship, and protecting everyone.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power in a fragile, unstable state is contested, but the decisions a careful effort can reach run through the custodianship and the partners: the **Bijagó traditional authority and customary law**, which govern the islands; the **conservation and protected-area bodies** that hold the Biosphere Reserve; the **fisheries authorities and the agreements** that govern the offshore access; and the **conservation, community, and international partners**. Keep clear of the trafficking and the political turmoil, and map who genuinely decides — and who can be reached safely — before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A harm — an offshore fishing depletion, a logging concession, a coastal development — advances through the state or the market, but on the archipelago it meets the Bijagó custodianship and the Biosphere Reserve. You enter there: through the traditional stewardship and the conservation designation, the fishing-agreement reform, the forest governance, and the environmental assessment. For the offshore fishing, the entry point is the agreements and the anti-illegal-fishing frameworks. Enter always through the custodianship and the partners, and safely.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the fishing: who buys the offshore access, what the agreements permit, and what illegal fishing depletes the waters. Follow the cashew and the forest: what drives the monoculture and the logging. Follow the archipelago: what the Biosphere Reserve and the Bijagó custodianship protect. The leverage lies in the custodianship and the designation, the fishing-agreement reform, and the forest governance.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Oversight in a fragile state is weak, but the Bijagó traditional authority, the conservation and protected-area bodies, the Biosphere Reserve framework, the fisheries agreements and anti-illegal-fishing bodies, and the conservation and international partners are the channels a careful case engages — holding each to the custodianship, the designation, and the agreements.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Bissau-Guinean effort easily halts a poverty-driven harm, and honesty requires saying so — the state sells the fishing access and the governance is unstable. But the Bijagó custodianship, the Biosphere Reserve, and the conservation partnerships are real and proven. The single most decisive move is **building on the proven Bijagó custodianship and the Biosphere Reserve designation**, because that stewardship has already conserved the archipelago for generations, and because the conservation partners

and international frameworks rally to it. The custodianship is the distinctive lever; the designation the durable protection; the fishing-agreement reform the sharpest handle on the offshore harm. The realistic prize is the archipelago defended, the fishing pressed toward reform, the forests and mangroves protected — pursued carefully, and never against the poor.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the offshore overfishing, the logging, the coastal development, the mangrove loss. **What protects the place?** — the Biosphere Reserve, the Bijagó custodianship, the fishing agreements. **What drives the harm?** — the poverty, the cashew trap, the sold access. **Which channel is safe?** — the custodianship, the conservation partners, the frameworks, kept clear of the trafficking. **How is everyone kept safe and the poor not punished?** — the overriding questions. Pick the harm where the custodianship and the designation offer the clearest, safest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, carefully. **Layer one: the harm** — the overfishing, logging, or coastal damage, and the treasure it threatens, documented with the conservation science. **Layer two: the protection** — the Biosphere Reserve, the Bijagó custodianship and customary law, the fishing agreements and anti-illegal-fishing frameworks the harm breaches or strains. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which conservation, custodianship, or international partner to reach, and the discipline of keeping clear of the trafficking and politics, protecting everyone, and never targeting the poor. A case built on the proven custodianship and the conservation designation is one the partners and frameworks rally to.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the overfishing and illegal-fishing data, the logging, the coastal and mangrove damage, the conservation science. Gather the **protection record**: the Biosphere Reserve designation, the Bijagó custodianship and customary law, the fishing agreements and anti-illegal-fishing frameworks. Gather the **driver record**: the poverty, the cashew dependence, the sold access. Gather the **channel record**: the conservation and international partners, the traditional authority, the community. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the work keeps clear of the trafficking and politics, protects everyone, and never targets the poor.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE CUSTODIANSHIP AND CONSERVATION COALITION

The coalition here rests on a proven custodianship. Build it from the **Bijagó traditional authority and community**, whose stewardship has conserved the islands; the **conservation and protected-area organisations and partners**, who bring science and support; the **fisheries reformers and anti-illegal-fishing bodies**; and the **international conservation partners and frameworks**. Frame the effort around the archipelago and the custodianship, never around the politics or the trafficking; protect everyone involved; and never turn the fight against the poor who fish and farm to survive — win them, with alternatives, as allies of the stewardship they share.

STEP 4: CUSTODIANSHIP, DESIGNATION & FISHERIES LEVERS — DEFENDING THE ARCHIPELAGO

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real and proven but constrained by poverty and instability, and the work must be careful and safe.

The Bijagó Custodianship and the Biosphere Reserve

The distinctive lever is the **Bijagós Biosphere Reserve and the proven Bijagó custodianship** — the sacred forests, customary law, and community stewardship that have conserved the islands for generations, backed by the international designation. Strengthen and invoke both: the traditional stewardship and the conservation framework together are the archipelago's strongest defence.

The Fisheries Reform and the Forests

The **offshore fishing that depletes the waters** can be pressed through the reform and transparency of the fishing-access agreements and the anti-illegal-fishing frameworks, and the **logging** through forest governance and law. Press the agreements toward sustainability, the illegal fishing toward enforcement, and the forests toward protection.

The Mangroves and the International Partners

The **mangroves and the coast** can be defended through conservation and the traditional rice system, and the **conservation and international partners and frameworks** offer real channels. Pursued together — the custodianship and designation, the fisheries and forests, and the international partners — these levers defend the archipelago, resting on the proven stewardship, while protecting everyone and never punishing the poor.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always resting on the custodianship. **For the traditional authority**: here is a harm to the islands your stewardship has always protected. **For the conservation and protected-area bodies**: here is a Biosphere Reserve treasure under threat. **For the fisheries reformers**: here is the offshore depletion and illegal fishing to press through the agreements and frameworks. **For the forest governance**: here is logging to address. **For the international partners**: here is a globally significant archipelago and a proven custodianship to support. **The golden rule**: build on the Bijagó custodianship and the designation, keep clear of the trafficking and politics, protect everyone, and never target the poor.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care in a fragile, trafficking-strained state. Frame the story around **the archipelago and its proven custodianship**: a globally significant treasure — the hippos, the turtles, the Bijagó stewardship — under pressure from overfishing and logging. Carry it through the international conservation outlets and partners, never through anything touching the trafficking or the politics. A few cautions govern everything: keep it strictly to the archipelago and conservation; keep clear of the trafficking and turmoil; protect everyone; never target the poor; and let the treasure, the custodianship, and the conservation science carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, custodianship-grounded, protective of everyone, and clear of the trafficking and politics.

8A — To the Bijagó traditional authority: set out the harm to the islands and build on the customary stewardship.

8B — To a conservation or protected-area body: connect the harm to the Biosphere Reserve and ask for its protection.

8C — On the fisheries: document the offshore depletion or illegal fishing and press for agreement reform and enforcement.

8D — On the forests: flag the logging and press the forest governance and law.

8E — On the mangroves: set out the coastal and mangrove harm and the traditional rice system at stake.

8F — To an international conservation partner: share the case and ask for support for the archipelago and the custodianship.

8G — To the community: set out the shared stake and the alternatives, and organise safely.

8H — To the international public: summarise the treasure and the threat, and ask for support — without touching the trafficking or exposing anyone.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: document the harm and the treasure it threatens; write the one-page case built on the custodianship and the Biosphere Reserve; reach the conservation partners and the traditional authority. **The fastest-moving levers:** the Bijagó custodianship, the Biosphere Reserve, and the international conservation partners. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the traditional authority and the conservation partners first — safely and clear of the trafficking. Throughout, protect everyone and never target the poor.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by deep poverty, a state that sells its fishing access, and chronic instability strained by trafficking. Recognise it and adjust the aim — not a single stop, but the archipelago defended and the harm pressed toward reform. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot easily reach: the proven Bijagó custodianship, the Biosphere Reserve designation, the anti-illegal-fishing frameworks, and the international conservation partners. And accept the honest limits — the poverty, the sold access, the instability — while still defending the treasure through the stewardship, and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — fishing access sold to insiders, logging concessions steered, the archipelago's protection undermined, and, gravely, the drug-trafficking that shadows the islands and the politics. Where capture or trafficking appears, respond only through the **safe channels**: the custodianship, the conservation partners, the international frameworks, the documented record. Never through anything touching the trafficking or the political turmoil, which must be kept clear of absolutely. **On safety and care:** this note matters here. Guinea-Bissau is fragile and trafficking-strained. Favour the custodianship,

conservation, community, and international channels; keep clear of the trafficking and political turmoil absolutely; protect everyone involved; frame the work strictly around the archipelago and conservation; never punish the poor; and handle the politics with strict neutrality. Care is the first rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, custodianship-grounded and safely. The documented harm feeds the designation defence, the fisheries reform, and the forest governance at once; the Bijagó, conservation, and international coalition organises alongside; the media carries the archipelago-and-custodianship frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and build on the custodianship and designation; **months two to six**, press the fisheries reform, the forest governance, and the international partners; **beyond**, sustain the archipelago's defence, resting on the proven stewardship. The core discipline: custodianship-grounded, conservation-channelled, clear of the trafficking and politics, and never against the poor.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Guinea-Bissau is a fragile, unstable ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a poverty-driven harm can simply be halted, or that the state will not sell its fishing access, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true, and the trafficking and instability are real dangers to keep clear of. But it rests on a genuine strength found almost nowhere else in this series: a proven, living Bijagó custodianship that has conserved one of West Africa's great natural treasures for generations, backed by a UNESCO Biosphere Reserve and genuine conservation partnerships. The levers are the custodianship and the designation, the fishing-agreement reform and the anti-illegal-fishing frameworks, the forest governance, and the international partners — and the prize is the archipelago defended, the fishing pressed toward reform, the forests and mangroves protected, resting on the proven stewardship, not a single triumphant stop. For a small, fragile archipelago nation with a living tradition of conservation, that careful, custodianship-grounded work — clear of the trafficking, protecting everyone, and never punishing the poor — is not a lesser ambition. It is the responsible and effective one.